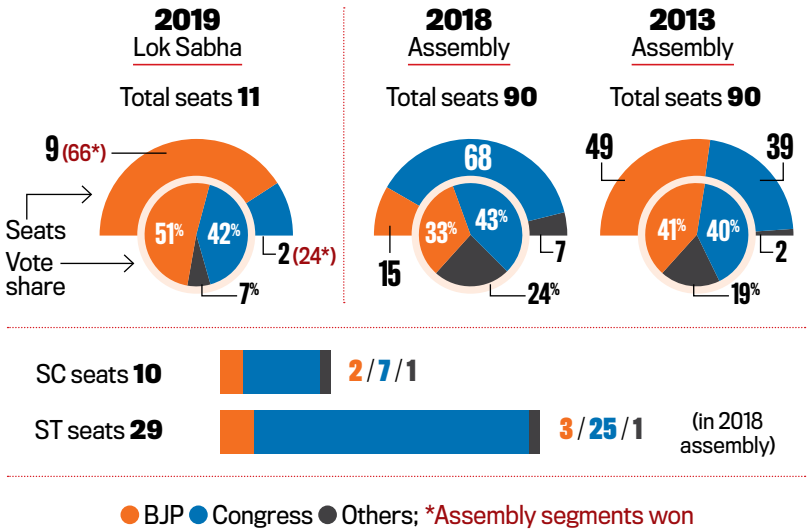
HOW THE TWO PARTIES PERFORMED



Source: Election Commission of India; Caste and region break-up with inputs from Axis My India and India Today bureau



WHILE BJP TRIES TO POLARISE COMMUNALLY VOLATILE INCIDENTS, CONGRESS IS REFUSING TO RISE TO ANY COMMUNAL BAIT, AND IS ALSO PRACTISING SOFT HINDUTVA ON THE SIDE

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Dismiss them as "revdis", as PM Modi did, or call them "guarantees", as the Congress has repurposed them, but the fact is welfarism and populism are here to stay in party manifestoes. The BJP, on its part, is continuing to cultivate the *labharthi varg*, the vote bank it has created out of the 120 million beneficiaries of the various central schemes. While its foot-soldiers pan out to different corners of these states to spread awareness about schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana, PM-KISAN (Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi) Scheme, Sukanya Samriddhi Scheme–Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, PM Garib Kalyan Yojana (PMGKY) and Ayushman Bharat, it had even roped in bureaucrats as "*rath prabharis*" to showcase the government's achievements in the past nine years till the Congress put a spanner in the works.

However, in the states that it does rule, the Congress is taking a leaf out of the BJP playbook. In MP, it announced the Padho-Padhao Yojana, promising free education to students from Class 1-12 and a monthly scholarship ranging from Rs 500 to Rs 1,500. To ensure the BJP did not introduce a scheme that would neutralise its promise, the Congress waited for the Model Code of Conduct to kick in before Priyanka Gandhi announced the scheme in Mandla. The Congress manifesto has more than 1,200 promises besides, including Rs 25 lakh health and Rs 10 lakh accidental insurance for all, 100 units of power for free, 200 units for half tariff, Rs 1,500 per month to every woman, Rs 1,500-3,000 monthly for two years to unemployed educated youth, restoration of Old Pension Scheme (OPS), waiving farm loans up to Rs 2 lakh, buying paddy from farmers at Rs 2,500 per quintal, wheat at Rs 2,600 per quintal, cow dung at Rs 2 per kg, and an Indian Premier League team from MP.

In Chhattisgarh, CM Baghel is highlighting welfare schemes like the Rajiv Gandhi Kisan Nyay and Godhan Nyay Yojanas, unemployment allowance, pro-